

MEDIA AND GOVERNMENT CENSORSHIP: EVIDENCE FROM MEXICO

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CONTEXT AND RESEARCH QUESTION

- ▶ Media outlets have been identified as a critical component of electoral accountability in Latin America ([Ferraz and Finan, 2008](#); [Enríquez et al., 2024](#); [Marshall, 2024](#)).
- ▶ Even in the absence of outright censorship, the government still has techniques to silence critics ([Besley and Prat, 2006](#); [Guriev and Treisman, 2020](#))
- ▶ In Mexico, there is anecdotal evidence that past administrations use the social communication spending for this purposes ([Ahmed, 2017](#)).

RQ1: How does the government react to media outlets being critic of it?

RQ2: How does the media react to censorship or critics coming from the President?

RESEARCH DESIGN RQ1

- ▶ Estimate the impact of critical coverage on government communication spending by media outlet.
- ▶ OLS probably biased due to time-based endogeneity and unobserved confounding factors related to criticism level and resource allocation.
- ▶ **Instrumental Variable (IV) Approach:** Use lottery assignment to the first, second or third row at morning press conferences as an instrument for $NumCr_{i,t}$.
- ▶ First Stage Equation:

$$NumCr_{i,t} = \theta_0 + \theta_1 FirstRow_{i,t} + \mathbf{X}'_{i,t} \gamma + \epsilon_{i,t}$$

FEEDBACK

- ▶ Any possible threats to the exclusion restriction that I should think about?
- ▶ I am struggling thinking about the period of analysis.
- ▶ If month then the instrument should be the number of times the media outlet was assigned to the first row that month.
- ▶ This probably affects the critical articles of that month, but the government spending? Or in $T+1$.

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RESEARCH DESIGN RQ2

- ▶ Narrative comparison between what the President said everyday in the press conference and what the media covered.
- ▶ H1: media reacts to attacks from the President by cherry-picking on the conference and switching the narrative.
- ▶ Use [Waight et al. \(2024\)](#) to extract all narratives from both sources, observationally compare them
- ▶ Heterogeneous analysis by media outlet ideology, topic discussed (violence related, controversial topics), etc.